



NEARLY 45 PER CENT of the sitting MPs are trounced in every election.

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nearly 45 per cent of the sitting MPs trounced. In 1999, 241 sitting MPs lost the polls. And it is a long-term trend. Voters in 174 constituencies have not re-elected their MPs since the past four elections and over 180 seats are won or lost within a margin of 5 per cent of polled votes. What the electors and the elected deem as anti-incumbency is simply the inability of politicians to overcome the system. All that the political class could come up with was the Rs 2 crore-per-MP-per-year Local Area Development Scheme which has become a tool for nepotism and rampant corruption. The late BJP leader Pramod Mahajan once characterised the inability to make the system deliver in his unique but rather telling manner. He said, "While we are elected and thrown out there is something called the permanent government and that is the babudom". The ability or inability to get this machine work is what makes the difference.

There is a belief among contestants that perceived clout and potential to occupy the high chair helps. This perception has a corollary where voters believe it will help their cause if they vote for a candidate who may

become a minister. But the reality of parliamentary constituencies is that electing iconic or powerful MPs does little for the constituency. In this perception race there would be nothing better than electing a potential prime minister or a sitting prime minister. A reality check busts this illusion. Barring Surat which elected Morarji Desai, none of the prime ministerial constituencies figure anywhere on the top 100 list. Nothing represents this reality better than Uttar Pradesh which has elected eight of the 14 prime ministers since 61 years of Independence.

Phulpur and Allahabad, represented by Jawaharlal Nehru, who was prime minister for 17 years, rank 409 out of 543 on the socio-economic index. Lucknow, which elected Atal Bihari Vajpayee, is placed at 269. Ballia, which elected Chandra Shekhar (and now his son), ranks 388 and Chaudhary Charan Singh's Baghpat is 362. Look at Amethi which has elected members of the Gandhi family—Sanjay Gandhi, Rajiv Gandhi (twice), Sonia Gandhi and now Rahul Gandhi—five times out of 10 polls. It ranks 484 on the socio-economic index and 475 on the infrastructure ranking. Rae Bareilly, which has elected a



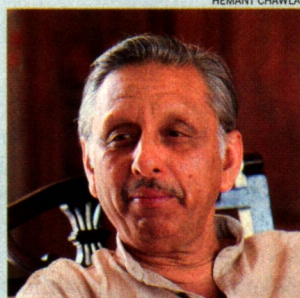
MEIRA KUMAR
SOCIAL JUSTICE MINISTER
SASARAM, BIHAR

RANK

Socio-economic Infrastructure

477 493

Sasaram elected Babu Jagjivan Ram eight times, and is now represented by his daughter, but hasn't received any loyalty bonus.



MANI SHANKAR AIYAR
PANCHAYATI RAJ MINISTER
MAYILADUTHURAI, TAMIL NADU

RANK

Socio-economic Infrastructure

79 157

It helps being located in a progressive state but needs investments and jobs to reach a higher orbit.



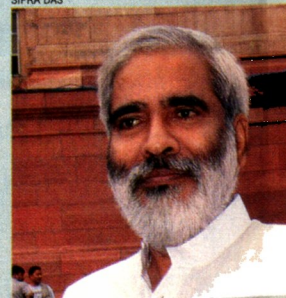
A. RAJA
COMMUNICATIONS & IT MINISTER
PERAMBALUR, TAMIL NADU

RANK

Socio-economic Infrastructure

64 113

Has pushed for investments but needs to use colleague T.R. Baalu and DMK Raj to improve infrastructure.



RAGHUVANSH PRASAD
RURAL DEVELOPMENT MINISTER
VAISHALI, BIHAR

RANK

Socio-economic Infrastructure

483 499

It is virtually ground zero and will require more than just rural development to lift this constituency.